Praying Mantis Kung Fu
The Five Gates



Taiji Meihua Praying Mantis training programme • English • 29 October 2026

What is Praying Mantis Kung Fu?

Praying Mantis (螳螂拳, tánglángquán) is a Chinese martial art. Kung fu and wushu refer here to Chinese martial arts. Its development is associated with Shandong province, including Laiyang. The name evokes the insect's grasping forelegs; training develops movement and martial techniques suited to the human body. [2]

This programme draws on the Taiji Meihua Praying Mantis tradition. Training includes body positions, footwork, strikes, grips and ways of controlling a partner's movement. Taiji forms part of the branch's name: this is not a course in taijiquan, commonly known as tai chi.

What are the five gates?

A gate means a learning stage in this programme. Meister Wulf has organised the material into five stages, progressing from simpler to more complex work. Each introduces a new focus while earlier skills remain part of training. Progress depends on demonstrated competence, not simply time spent training.

> The sequence of gates, time estimates and assessment tasks are Meister Wulf's teaching arrangement. They are not Master Wang Xiuyuan's (王秀远, Wáng Xiùyuǎn) official grading system or Chinese duanwei grades.

Stage	Main focus	Forms studied
1	Balance and basic positions	Zhǐlù
2	Handwork and contact	Xiǎo Fānchē; Méihuālù
3	Applying force and timing	Lánjié; Bēngbù
4	Whole-body coordination at close range	Fēnshēn Bāzhǒu, sections 1-4
5	Bringing skills together	Zhāiyào, sections 1-6; weapon forms

Three continuing aims: control of your own body; understanding techniques and practising them with a partner; attention, self-control and responsibility for your partner.

A form, or tàolù, is a sequence of movements practised in a set order. Partner exercises explore how selected movements can be used in agreed situations. Terms and form names are explained on pages 6-7; editorial notes and sources are on pages 8-9.

The first and second gates

1. Balance and basic positions · 立身 lìshēn

Aim. Learn to stand and move with balance, coordinating the legs, trunk and arms.

- Eight basic stances. The instructor demonstrates foot placement, weight distribution and the positions of the trunk and arms. Names such as 'horse stance' are memory aids; each needs a physical description.
- In basic positions, keep the head aligned with the trunk and avoid unnecessary tension in the shoulder girdle. The knees track in the direction of the feet; avoid allowing them to collapse inwards. [5]
- Learn Zhǐlù (指路, 'pointing the way') and practise striking a pad. The legs, hips, trunk and striking arm work together.
- In balance exercises, your partner applies light, agreed pressure. The aim is to remain in control of your position, rather than to stay motionless at any cost.

Assessment. Demonstrate the eight stances and the complete form, maintain balance under light pressure, and explain knee and shoulder-girdle positioning.

Source estimate: 6-12 months. See the note on the interpretation of time estimates on page 8.

2. Handwork and contact · 明手 míngshǒu

Aim. Learn to establish and maintain contact and respond to your partner's movement. Contact here means touch between the hands or forearms.

- Twelve principles: 黏、粘、帮、贴、来、叫、顺、送、提、拿、封、闭. They concern contact, coordination, direction and control. Each is explained on page 7; a character does not stand for just one fixed technique.
- The forms Xiǎo Fānchē (小翻车) and Méihuālù (梅花路). Learn their sequence and practise selected applications with a partner.
- In contact exercises, maintain light hand contact, change direction slowly and look for an appropriate moment to act. This exercise does not include strikes to the body.
- Qínná (擒拿) means gripping and controlling techniques. Practise wrist and elbow control and releases from grips. Restrict joint movement slowly, stopping before pain.

Assessment. Explain the twelve principles and demonstrate examples with a partner. Perform both forms and the control techniques and releases learnt, on both sides of the body.

Source estimate: 1-1.5 years.

The third and fourth gates

3. Applying force and timing · 懂劲 dǒngjìn

Aim. Learn to apply force through coordinated movement and recognise the direction and changes of your partner's pressure. Jìn (劲) here means force applied through coordination and timing.

- Bēngchuí (崩捶): a particular strike with a short path of movement. Learn its timing and reduce unnecessary tension after contact.
- Firm and yielding actions (刚／柔, gāng/róu). Depending on the situation, choose when to resist, yield to or redirect your partner's movement.
- The forms Lánjié (拦截) and Bēngbù (崩步). Begin sparring under agreed rules, with protective equipment, limited force and permitted targets on the trunk and arms.
- Releases from holds around the head, neck and shoulders. Practise release from a starting position without applying pressure or twisting force to the neck.

Assessment. Perform both forms. Deliver ten controlled pad strikes while maintaining technique and balance. In a light contact exercise, optionally with eyes closed, describe the direction and changes of pressure. Complete two sparring rounds of a duration and intensity set by the instructor.

Source estimate: 1.5-2 years. Assessment concerns control and decisions, not defeating a partner or claiming equal striking force without measurement.

4. Whole-body coordination at close range · 分身 fēnshēn

Aim. Learn to coordinate hands, elbows, shoulders, hips and knees at close range.

- Fēnshēn Bāzhǒu (分身八肘), sections 1-4: an advanced series of forms. Its name is not treated as an instruction to use only eight elbow strikes.
- Practise close-range strikes on pads first. Partner exercises use controlled techniques selected by the instructor and suitable protective equipment.
- Before learning throws, practise four falling techniques selected by the instructor. Work on mats and protect the head. Add control techniques involving the fingers and hip region.
- Learn the legal limits of self-defence and lead a 15-minute part of a beginners' session with the instructor present.

Assessment. Perform the sections learnt, demonstrate a throw and fall on both sides, and lead part of a session. In an agreed awareness exercise, notice an additional partner, maintain distance and move towards safety. Do not stage an unexpected attack from behind.

Source estimate: about 2 years. Principles of lawful defence in Estonia are explained on page 5.

The fifth gate and a typical session

5. Bringing skills together · 摘要 zhāiyào

Aim. Integrate earlier learning: choose movement suited to the situation, adapt techniques and explain them to others.

- Zhāiyào (摘要), sections 1-6: an advanced series of forms. The word refers to bringing together key points; ‘essence’ is a figurative translation, not its only possible meaning. [3]
- Traditional training weapons: sabre (刀, dāo), spear (枪, qiāng), straight sword (剑, jiàn) and staff (棍, gùn). Learn to coordinate body and implement, judge distance and control the implement.
- Control techniques involving the knee and foot. Learn to recognise actions that risk injury, stop training and call for help.
- Agreed scenario exercises with several partners. The aim is awareness, distance and escape, not overcoming several opponents.
- Under supervision, plan and lead a complete training session and assist with assessment. This does not automatically confer a coaching qualification.

Assessment. Perform the Zhāiyào sections learnt and two weapon forms studied. Apply your skills in partner work under agreed rules, lead a complete session and identify your teachers and teaching lineage.

Learning continues: this stage has no fixed end date. Weapon practice uses training implements suited to the task and adequate spacing.

The usual structure of a session

Part	Activity
1. Warm-up	Movements to warm the body, joint mobility exercises, basic stances and footwork.
2. Form practice	A form from the current stage, either complete or in shorter sequences.
3. Partner practice	Apply a movement in an agreed situation; later the partner introduces one variable.
4. Pads or mats	Striking technique, falling or throwing, as appropriate to the stage.
5. Cool-down	Gentle movement and breathing; finish with three slow steps.

Getting started

The first months focus on basic positions, footwork and the first form. No previous knowledge of Chinese or martial arts is required. According to the source programme, training takes place in Veskimöldre, near Laagri in the Tallinn area. Ask the instructor for the exact location and timetable.

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Safety and teaching tradition

Agreements that apply at every stage

- **Stop signal.** Two quick taps or the word ‘stop’ mean stop the technique and release the hold immediately. Do not wait for another tap if the partner has already given a clear signal to stop.
- **Joint control.** Apply techniques slowly, without jerking and without reaching pain. Absence of pain does not establish that a joint is in a safe position.
- **Excluded targets and actions.** Basic sparring in this programme excludes strikes to the head, neck, spinal area and groin. Chokes and forceful twisting of the head or neck are excluded. Starting holds used to teach releases remain unloaded.
- **Sparring.** Agree permitted techniques, targets, force, speed, duration and protective equipment before starting. Protective equipment does not permit unlimited force. Head strikes are not introduced automatically at the fifth gate.
- **Throws and control techniques.** Learn under supervision on suitable mats. Finger, knee and foot locks are not used in free sparring.
- **Reporting injury.** Stop and tell the instructor if you experience pain, numbness or feel unwell. Headache, dizziness or confusion after an impact may indicate concussion: do not return to training that day, and obtain assessment by a healthcare professional. [7] Numbness or weakness after an impact requires urgent medical assessment. [8]
- **Responsibility.** Training serves learning and health. In conflict, prefer leaving and seeking help when possible. Supporting another person does not necessarily require physical confrontation.
- **Order of learning.** First learn the version passed on by your teacher. Other teachers may teach different versions; a difference alone does not make a version incorrect.

Lawful defence in Estonia

Defence concerns an unlawful attack already happening or immediately impending. Its limits are exceeded when a defender acts purposefully or with direct intent, using means manifestly out of proportion to the danger or causing manifestly excessive harm. An opportunity to leave does not remove the right to defend. This summarises § 28 of the Estonian Penal Code; individual cases require the law and circumstances to be considered. [6]

Lineage and the division of qínná

The source links the school to the Weifang Taiji Meihua Praying Mantis lineage and to teaching begun in Estonia in 1991. It describes Wang Xiuyuan’s recommendation to learn Meihua material before Taiji material. For the lineage account referred to as ‘Palvetajaritsika kaanon’ (‘The Praying Mantis Canon’) in the source, ask Meister Wulf.

According to the source, Wang Xiuyuan’s qínná teaching has ten units: ‘small qínná’ (小擒拿, Xiǎo Qínná), units 1-5, and ‘large qínná’ (大擒拿, Dà Qínná), units 6-10. Each contains 36 techniques, making 72 in total. This is a lineage-specific account, not a universal classification. The five gates do not correspond one-to-one with the ten qínná units.

Glossary and form names

Pinyin writes Chinese using the Latin alphabet. Marks above vowels indicate tones, not English stress. The explanations below describe how the terms are used in this programme.

Chinese	Pinyin	Explanation
螳螂拳	tánglángquán	Praying Mantis martial art; 拳 refers here to a martial style.
关	guān	'Gate'; a learning stage in this programme.
桩／站桩	zhuāng / zhànzhuāng	桩 originally means a post; 站桩 is standing practice. 'Post' is not a complete definition of every stance.
劲	jìn	Skilfully directed force involving coordination and timing.
套路	tàolù	Form: a sequence of movements in a set order.
段	duàn	A section of a form or teaching material; not a duanwei grade here.
擒拿	qínná	Gripping and controlling techniques, including joint control.
拆／拆招	chāi / chāizhāo	Explaining movements from a form and practising applications.
靠	kào	Using the body at close range, for example with the shoulder.
刚／柔	gāng / róu	Firm / yielding action, rather than stiffness / weakness.
虚／实	xū / shí	Depending on context: unweighted / weighted or apparent / actual action.
师父	shīfu	Master or teacher in a traditional teacher-disciple relationship. The general word for coach is 教练, jiàoliàn.

Form names used in the programme

Written name	Pinyin	How to understand the name
指路	Zhǐlù	'Pointing the way'; the name of a form.
小翻车	Xiǎo Fānchē	A traditional form name; 'small turning cart' is one figurative rendering.
梅花路	Méihuālù	'Plum-blossom route'; 路 here refers to a sequence.
拦截	Lánjié	'Intercepting'; the name of a form.
崩步	Bēngbù	A form name; 'bursting step' is not a precise movement instruction.
分身八肘	Fēnshēn Bāzhǒu	A series focusing on close-range work; sections 1-4 in this programme.
摘要	Zhāiyào	A series bringing together key points; sections 1-6 in this programme.

Names have been standardised for this edition. Exact lineage spellings should be checked against the teacher's material; similar-sounding names in different branches should not automatically be treated as identical.

The twelve principles

These explanations support learning the characters given in the source. They do not replace the teacher's examples or define a single interpretation shared by every Praying Mantis branch. Wording and characters can vary by lineage. [4]

Term	Pinyin	Meaning and connection with practice
黏	nián	Staying attached: maintaining contact while adapting to the partner's movement.
粘	zhān	Attaching or making contact. Its distinction from the preceding term depends on the teaching tradition.
帮	bāng	Helping or supporting: the hands and body support one another's action.
贴	tiē	Staying close or adhering: reducing distance and working in close contact.
来	lái	Coming: recognising and responding to an approaching action.
叫	jiào	Eliciting: prompting a response or movement from the partner.
顺	shùn	Following: taking account of the direction of movement or force.
送	sòng	Sending on: continuing or directing a movement onwards.
提	tí	Lifting: an upward action as required by the exercise.
拿	ná	Grasping and controlling: limiting the partner's available movement.
封	fēng	Blocking: closing a route of attack or movement.
闭	bì	Closing: restricting an opening or opportunity to act. This is a different character from 逼 (bī).

> 黏 and 粘 overlap in meaning and usage. The nián/zhān distinction helps the reader follow the source; it does not establish a universal distinction between maintaining and creating contact. Some lineages use 逼 rather than 闭, as well as other variants. Do not substitute characters without the teacher's confirmation.

Describing movement clearly

A useful description follows this order: starting position, movement, finishing position and an observable objective. 'Mountain climbing' or 'swallowing stance' may be memorable names, but they do not independently tell a beginner where to place the feet or distribute weight. [1]

For example, replace the general instruction 'be rooted' with: 'Keep the supporting foot firmly on the floor and maintain balance under light pressure.' This is an accessible explanation, not a complete technical description of one particular traditional stance.

The stage names 立身、明手、懂劲、分身 and 摘要 are linked here to this programme's topics. Their use together does not establish a nationally recognised Chinese five-stage curriculum.